Gender-Associated Bias in Neural Rerankers — An Empirical Audit and De-Identification Test

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Abstract

Automated hiring pipelines can retrieve candidate documents with an embedding model and then reorder the leading candidates with a neural reranker. Bias in embedding models is well documented, but rerankers are a different class of model, and few studies have tested how they respond to a candidate's name and pronouns. We audit 29 current commercial and open-weight rerankers with controlled name-and-pronoun comparisons; to our knowledge, no earlier bias study of rerankers covers this many models or includes the commercial reranking services sold today. Each model scores the same 8,320 document pairs, and within each pair, qualifications are unchanged and only the selected name and pronouns differ. In 27 of the 29 models, the male-associated document is favored more often for male-typed occupations than for female-typed occupations, and in each of these the difference is larger than all 10,000 placebo differences built from random pairs of same-gender names; of the two recent exceptions, one shows no difference and the other a reverse pattern that does not survive adjustment for multiple comparisons. When both names are replaced by one placeholder, so that the two documents differ only in their pronouns, the pattern holds in 27 of 28 re-scored models. On whole real résumés, testing with job categories as the units, 11 of the 22 tested rerankers that show the pattern keep it, all but one at a smaller size, and 4 reverse it (18 keep it under a less cautious test that holds the categories fixed), so how much of it carries over depends on the model. In synthetic pools of 20 candidates whose documents differ only in name and pronouns, one retrieval-and-reranking pipeline assigns 79% of top-3 positions to male-associated documents; behind the same retriever, the audited pointwise rerankers range from 44% to 85% (median 63%), against 60% for retrieval alone. Results vary materially across models, occupations, names, templates, and query wordings. We then test a simple input transform that replaces names with one placeholder and gendered pronouns with one uniform token before ranking. The transform makes each counterfactual pair textually identical and therefore removes score differences attributable to those markers by construction. On a near-ceiling synthetic occupation-matching check, the transform did not reduce top-rank accuracy (827 of 832 correct before, 830 after). On whole real résumés, where the task is not at ceiling, it changed top-rank accuracy by -3.8 to 0.4 points across 5 rerankers, no change distinguishable from zero, and lowered one reranker's nDCG@10, a measure of the whole top ten, by 2.1 points. These findings establish sensitivity to the tested names and pronouns, rather than discrimination in deployed hiring or a complete solution to demographic bias.

1 Introduction

Modern search systems commonly retrieve a candidate set with a fast first-stage method, such as lexical matching or a dense embedding model [11], and then use a more expensive model to rerank that set [18]. The same architecture can be used for job and resume matching. A candidate must therefore pass two learned ordering stages before appearing near the top of a recruiter's list.

Prior work on social bias spans several other model types. Word and text embeddings encode social stereotypes [8, 20]. Large language models that grade résumés directly show gender and racial effects whose direction differs across models [1]. Embedding-based résumé retrieval favors some demographic groups when only the name changes [28]. A hiring study of four commercial embedding models finds that swapping a résumé's first name changes which candidates reach the top of the ranking, but that swapping between two names of the same group, or adding typographical errors, does so as well [25]. Rerankers are a different type of model. Rather than comparing precomputed vectors, a reranker typically reads the query and a candidate document together and outputs a relevance score, and in a retrieval pipeline it sits on top of the embedding stage, reordering the candidates that retrieval returns. Findings about embedding models therefore cannot be assumed to carry over to rerankers. Work on rerankers themselves is less extensive and mostly concerns general search. Counterfactual inputs have probed rerankers for lexical sensitivity: rewriting passages to remove keyword overlap with the query changes the relevance judgments of LLM-based rerankers [16]. LLMs prompted to rank documents have been evaluated for gender and geographic fairness [27], and six recent rerankers have been compared on group exposure [23], both on TREC Fair Ranking data and with the documents left unchanged. BERT rankers were shown to return more male-skewed passages for gender-neutral queries [21, 22], and later work reduced this skew through bias-aware query revision, bias-aware sampling of training documents, or a neutrality penalty during training [4, 5, 29]. A related dataset pairs gender-neutral queries with male, female, and neutral versions of each document that differ only in gendered words [13]. Closest to our setting, Kumar and colleagues swapped a placeholder name, a title, and pronouns in candidate biographies, scored both versions with a cross-encoder they had trained, and used the pairs to find the job-advertisement words behind the score difference [14]. A follow-up reuses that counterfactual, with the candidate as the query and job advertisements as the ranked documents, for two such cross-encoders [15]. None of these studies tests a commercial reranking service or compares released rerankers on the same counterfactual candidate documents.

We ask three narrow empirical questions. First, do current rerankers score otherwise identical professional documents differently when selected names and pronouns change? Second, how do such differences affect a two-stage shortlist? Third, which simple de-identification rules remove the measured difference without reducing performance on a basic relevance check?

Our contribution is an audit of 29 current rerankers, commercial and open-weight, in which every model scores the same documents with only the name and pronouns changed. To our knowledge, no earlier bias study of rerankers covers this many models or includes commercial reranking services. Earlier counterfactual tests of candidate text used one placeholder name per gender and one or two cross-encoders that the authors trained [14, 15]; this audit uses 10 pairs of common given names and rerankers as their developers release them. The audit has three parts. First, 27 of the 29 audited rerankers favor the male-associated version more often on male-typed than on female-typed occupations, including some of the most recently released models. The pattern holds in 27 of 28 re-scored models when the two documents differ only in their pronouns, so it does not depend on the names. On whole real résumés it persists in 11 of the 22 tested rerankers that show it (18 under a less cautious test), all but one at a smaller size, and reverses in 4. Second, in a retrieval-and-reranking

simulation, the reranker can override the shortlist that retrieval produces. Third, on four locally runnable rerankers, replacing names and pronouns together removes the measured difference, while replacing names alone does not; on whole real résumés, the full replacement costs little ranking quality for all but one of 5 rerankers. The audit is dated and reproducible, and it makes no claim about any employer's deployed system. The design isolates sensitivity to the changed text. Names carry associations beyond gender, but the pronoun-only comparison reproduces the pattern without them. The audit does not measure actual hiring decisions.

2 Experimental design

Counterfactual documents

Each observation is a pair of short professional documents. The two versions describe the same occupation, experience, skills, and accomplishments. One version uses a male-associated given name and masculine pronouns; the other uses a female-associated given name and feminine pronouns. Like correspondence studies of hiring, which randomly assign different names to comparable job applications [3], and like template-based audits of language systems in which only a name or a gendered word changes [12], the design varies the name, and here also the pronouns, while holding the rest of the document fixed. For a deterministic reranker that scores each document independently, any within-pair score difference is therefore caused by the changed name and pronoun tokens. Each API request held all 80 documents for one query, that is, one occupation in one query phrasing (4 templates $\times$ 10 name pairs $\times$ 2 versions), ordered template by template with the male-associated version of each pair first. IBM's Granite endpoint accepted at most 32 documents per request, so its requests were split; the listwise jina-reranker-v3, run from its public weights, received the same 80-document lists.

Vendors do not guarantee that a document's score is independent of its position in a request. We therefore re-sent the original requests for a category-balanced subset of 3,840 pairs (8 occupations per category, drawn with a fixed seed) to 15 of the 16 rerankers we accessed through an API (all except IBM's Granite reranker, whose endpoint could not be re-queried) in three layouts: unchanged; with each pair reversed, so that the female-associated version comes first; and with all of a request's documents in a seeded random order. An identical repeat of the unchanged layout measures run-to-run variability. Results are reported in Section 3.

Because names can also signal age, ethnicity, nationality, and individual identity, the name-and-pronoun comparison cannot attribute the whole difference to gender alone. We therefore also score a pronoun-only version of every comparison, in which both names are replaced by the same placeholder, so that the two documents differ only in their pronouns; this is the names-only de-identification rule below. We scored it on 2026-10-16 for every audited model except the listwise jina-reranker-v3, whose scores depend on the other documents in a request. The API models were re-queried, the open-weight models were re-run on an Apple M4 Pro, and IBM's Granite reranker, whose endpoint could not be re-queried, was scored from its public weights. Because every model scored ten names of each gender for each occupation, template, and query phrasing, swaps between two names of the same gender are also available from the original scores; Section 3 uses them as a yardstick for the size of the gender swap and as a placebo for the contrast.

We combine 4 document templates, 4 query phrasings, and 10 pairs of common American given names. Names come from national birth-name records [26]. Each pair joins one male-associated and one female-associated name; the pairing itself is arbitrary, and Section 3 checks that it does not

drive the results. The complete templates, queries, and names appear in Appendix A.

The 82 occupation words were assembled by hand before any labeling, from occupations chosen for this study and from the occupation list used in earlier work on embedding bias [20], which draws on the BIG-bench gender-occupation data. They are everyday job words, not a sample of the labor market, and some (for example, boss, warrior, or socialite) name a rank or role rather than an occupation; the labeling step below removes these. Statements about how many models or occupations show an effect therefore describe this benchmark, not the distribution of occupations in employment or job postings. We label occupations with the share of women employed in the corresponding federal labor-force category [7]. An occupation is male-typed if women hold under 30% of its jobs, female-typed if they hold over 70%, and evenly split if they hold 40% to 60%; the bands in between are excluded as ambiguous. We retain 52 occupations with a clear label: 18 male-typed, 21 female-typed, and 13 close to evenly split. The remaining 30 lack a usable match, have a suppressed estimate, or fall in an intentionally ambiguous range. The released repository records every inclusion and exclusion, its federal category, and the exclusion reason.

Rerankers and analysis

We evaluate 29 rerankers from commercial APIs and open-weight releases. The model set is a convenience sample, not a market sample: it comprises commercial rerankers we could query at scoring time through Voyage AI's and Google Cloud's APIs, Microsoft Azure, or the OpenRouter routing service, and open-weight rerankers published on Hugging Face by major model developers that run on a single 24 GB GPU and are licensed for research use. Scores for 14 models were collected on 2026-02-24. The remaining 15 were added from 2026-10-16 to 2026-10-17 with the same documents, queries, and request layout: through vendors' APIs or the OpenRouter routing service, or from public weights at pinned revisions on a rented NVIDIA RTX 4090. The first 14 models were scored on all 82 occupation words and the later 15 only on the 52 retained ones; only one robustness check in Section 3, which moves the cut-points, uses the others. Each open-weight model scored on the rented GPU passed a short occupation-matching check before its full run. A further endpoint, semantic-ranker-default-003, returned scores identical to semantic-ranker-default-004 on every row; we treat the two as one model and exclude the duplicate from every reported figure. Appendix B lists each model's identifier, access route, score range, overall tie rate, and collection date, with its results.

For each model and occupation group, we report whether the male-associated version scores higher, the versions tie, or the female-associated version scores higher. When a single directional share is needed, a tie contributes one half to each side; we call this the tie-aware share. Ties largely reflect score resolution rather than indifference: several models return coarsely rounded scores, and one open-weight reranker, run in bfloat16, emits only 254 distinct values across 16,640 scored documents. Confidence intervals are percentile intervals from a cluster bootstrap that resamples occupations, because comparisons within an occupation are not independent: 1,000 replications for per-category shares and 50,000 for the male-typed versus female-typed contrasts and the order test (seed 20260822); a few robustness checks use fewer, as their tables state. They describe uncertainty over occupations for this benchmark, holding the names, templates, and query phrasings fixed; with 18 and 21 clusters in the two categories, the percentile intervals are approximate. As a sensitivity check, we also resample the 48 federal labor-force categories instead of the 52 occupations, so that occupations sharing a category move together, and we resample occupations and name pairs jointly; the interval for the contrast between male-typed and female-typed occupations stays above zero for 27 of the 29 models under the first check and 27 under the second. Because these intervals

are approximate and unadjusted for the number of models, we also test each contrast with a two-sided permutation test that randomly relabels which occupations are male-typed and which are female-typed (1,000,000 relabelings), with a Holm adjustment across the 29 models. Because the 30% and 70% cut-points are a choice, we also treat the share of women as a continuous variable and repeat the contrast at other cut-points. Scores from different models have different scales, so we compare directions and within-model gaps rather than raw magnitudes across models.

Two-stage shortlist simulation

We form synthetic pools of 20 equally qualified documents: one document, with its occupation, template, and query fixed, in its 20 name-and-pronoun versions, half male- and half female-associated, so that every candidate in a pool is identical except for those markers. The retriever BAAI/bge-large-en-v1.5 selects the top 10 candidates. The reranker BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3 then produces a top-3 shortlist. We use this pair as the worked example because both are open-weight models from the same developer that can be re-run locally; Appendix C shows where the reranker falls among all audited models. We also evaluate the retriever and reranker separately and repeat the pipeline with every audited reranker behind the same retriever. The simulation reuses the reranker scores from the single-stage audit rather than rescoring each pool. This is exact for a reranker that scores documents independently; for the API rerankers, which scored each document inside a larger per-query request, it assumes the scores do not depend on the other documents in the request. We test that assumption directly by sending the retriever's actual ten documents for 104 sampled pools to each reachable API reranker and comparing the resulting shortlists with the replayed ones (Section 3). The sample takes 2 pools from every retained occupation, drawing their templates and query phrasings at random without repeats, and uses the same pools for every model. Exact score ties at a selection cutoff are broken at random, and each of the 832 pools is averaged over 200 such draws. Because candidate qualifications are identical by construction, departures from an even shortlist reflect ordering effects from the changed markers. For the same reason, a consistent score difference of any size fills the shortlist exactly as a large one would, so the simulation measures the direction and consistency of a model's preference rather than its size, and it is a stress test rather than an estimate for pools of genuinely different candidates.

De-identification

We test three rules: replace names only, neutralize pronouns only, and both. Each rule changes only the words it replaces, and it inserts the replacement in lowercase, even at the start of a sentence. The full rule replaces every detected name with "the candidate" and every gendered pronoun (he, she, him, his, her, hers, himself, herself) with the single word "they", which avoids deciding whether a given "her" is possessive or an object; Appendix D adds four comparison conditions, including rewrites that map "her" to "their", to "them", or according to the next word. Under the full rule the two counterfactual versions become the same string, so any deterministic pointwise reranker, whose only inputs are the query and the document, must score them identically; this is a symmetry guarantee, not a discovery. A listwise reranker, which also reads the other candidates and their positions, is guaranteed this only for a candidate held at the same position in an otherwise unchanged list, and ties at a selection cutoff still need a tie-breaking rule that ignores the replaced markers. Rules that replace names collapse the ten name pairs into one text, leaving 832 distinct comparisons repeated across the 8,320 rows.

We apply all rules to four open-weight rerankers, and the names-only rule, as the pronoun-only

comparison, to every model we could re-score. On the worked reranker, a synthetic occupation-matching check builds one pool per document template, each holding one document for every retained occupation (52 documents), and ranks each pool for every occupation's query in each of the 4 phrasings: 832 ranking events in all. Success means ranking the queried occupation's document first. Because every document names its occupation and the rules never touch that word, the check is near ceiling by design: it confirms that the occupation signal survives, not that ranking quality or selection within an occupation is preserved.

A second check uses whole real résumés, on which the task is not at ceiling. For each of the 24 job queries of the companion experiment (Appendix E), we drew 10 sets of 3 résumés from the query's category and 17 from the others (240 sets, 2,127 distinct résumés); a résumé counts as relevant if it comes from the query's category. As in the companion experiment, each résumé first gets a prepended given name and surname. Each set is ranked with the résumés as written and after the full rule, which here replaces the applicant's own name, as an employer could from the application, the other person names that an off-the-shelf detector finds, and every gendered pronoun (Appendix D). We report top-1 accuracy and nDCG@10 per set, with 95% intervals that resample the job queries, for 5 rerankers that read a whole résumé: Voyage rerank-3, Cohere rerank v5 pro, and the three open-weight models of the companion experiment that run on a laptop, bge-reranker-v2-m3, gte-reranker-modernbert-base, and granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2.

3 Results

Reranker scores track occupational gender composition

In 27 of the 29 audited models, the male-associated document is favored more often for male-typed occupations than for female-typed occupations, with an occupation-clustered interval above zero. The two exceptions are recent releases. The listwise jina-reranker-v3 shows no difference (0.8 points, interval −1.9 to 3.5). gte-reranker-modernbert-base shows the reverse pattern (−6.7 points, interval −12.7 to −0.3), although its interval includes zero when name pairs are resampled as well (−13.9 to 0.5). Appendix B lists every model's contrast with its intervals; these are individual 95% intervals, not adjusted for the 29 comparisons. The permutation test gives the same 27 models a positive contrast that survives the Holm adjustment, while the reverse pattern of gte-reranker-modernbert-base does not (adjusted p = 0.10). The cut-points do not drive this result. Treating the federal share of women as a continuous variable, a model's occupation-level male-favored share falls as the share of women rises in 28 of the 29 models (median Spearman ρ −0.75; 27 remain significant after a Holm adjustment of a 100,000-draw permutation test), by a median 4.6 points per 10 points of women's share; the exception is again gte-reranker-modernbert-base ($\rho = 0.29$). Moving the cut-points to 25% and 75% leaves 28 models positive and 27 intervals above zero, and for the 14 models scored on all 82 occupations, cut-points of 35% and 65%, which add 5 occupations from the excluded bands, leave all 14 positive (Table A4). All 29 models score the same documents, so these counts describe one benchmark seen through 29 models, not independent replications. Some recently released models show the largest differences, including zerank-2 (65 points) and Voyage rerank-3 (61 points). Within Voyage's two product lines, the only ones with three or more versions in the audit, the contrast rises with each version: 32, 57, 58, and 61 points for Voyage rerank-1, rerank-2, rerank-2.5, and rerank-3, and 19, 35, and 50 points along the lite line, where part of the rise coincides with a tie rate that falls from 21% to 14% (Table A1). These are descriptive comparisons of three or four products; the audit does not test for a trend over release dates. Across models, the median tie-aware male-favored share is 74% on male-typed occupations and 38% on

female-typed occupations; the two medians are taken separately and need not come from the same model. Within a single model, the median gap between the two categories is 31 percentage points (range −7 to 65). The size varies widely across models.

Names are not needed for this pattern. When both names are replaced by the same placeholder, so that the two documents differ only in their pronouns, the contrast has an occupation-clustered interval above zero for 27 of the 28 re-scored models (Table A3); the exception is again gte-reranker-modernbert-base (−8.6 points, interval −17.2 to 0.1). Pronouns, which carry no ethnic or age association, are therefore enough to produce the stereotype-aligned pattern.

The pronoun-only contrast is also larger, with a median of 39.5 points against 31.5 with names, but this does not show that pronouns matter more than names. Most of the gap comes from how the comparisons are grouped. With one placeholder, the ten name pairs that share an occupation, template, and query phrasing become a single comparison; with names, each pair is its own comparison, and a model's preferences among particular names turn some pairs the other way. Averaging each group's ten male-version and ten female-version scores before comparing raises the median with names to 37.5 (Table A3). Two smaller differences remain: the pronoun-only texts were scored in a later run, for the open-weight models on another machine (see the reproducibility checks below), and the placeholder changes the surface of the text, since it is inserted in lowercase (Appendix D). Without the 5 models whose re-run changed some checked winners, the medians are 37.0 with names averaged and 38.2 with pronouns only, and 37.5 and 37.4 if jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual, whose full re-score changed 3% of its winners, is also left out.

Evenly split occupations reveal substantial model variation. The median male-favored share is 64%, but 21 models lie above an even split and 8 lie below it. For 6 models, the occupation-clustered confidence interval includes an even split, and for 10 when name pairs are resampled as well (1,000,000 draws). A deployer therefore cannot infer either the size or direction of a model's behavior without testing that model. Part of any overall lean, however, reflects a model's preferences among particular names rather than their gender; the same-gender comparison below separates the two.

The level is not invariant to design choices. Across document templates, query phrasings, and name pairs, the median model's male-favored share ranges over 19, 22, and 35 percentage points respectively, so variation across names is especially large; the full tables are released with the data. Template-based bias measurements are known to shift considerably even under semantically equivalent rewrites of the templates [24]. The direction of the contrast is steadier. It is positive in all four templates for 24 models and in all four query phrasings for 25 (107 and 109 of 116 model-level cells), and comparing every male-associated name with every female-associated name, rather than only the fixed pairs, leaves it positive for 28 models. The audit establishes model sensitivity to the selected markers; part of the name effect on the level may still come from associations other than gender.

Swapping two names of the same gender gives a yardstick for the size of these differences and a placebo for their specificity. Within each cell of the design (one occupation, template, and query phrasing) every model scored ten male-associated and ten female-associated documents, so the 74,880 pairs that exchange one male-associated name for another, or one female-associated name for another, hold gender fixed and change only the name. Scores are on each model's own scale, so the comparison is within models (Table A5). The name-and-pronoun swap moves a model's score further than a same-gender name swap in 27 of the 29 models (median ratio of mean absolute gaps 1.7; interval above one for 27), and the median model's cross-gender gap exceeds the same-gender median of its own cell in 65% of pairs. The exceptions are the listwise jina-reranker-v3 (0.79) and Cohere rerank v4 pro (0.97, interval 0.90 to 1.06), whose gender swap moves its score no further

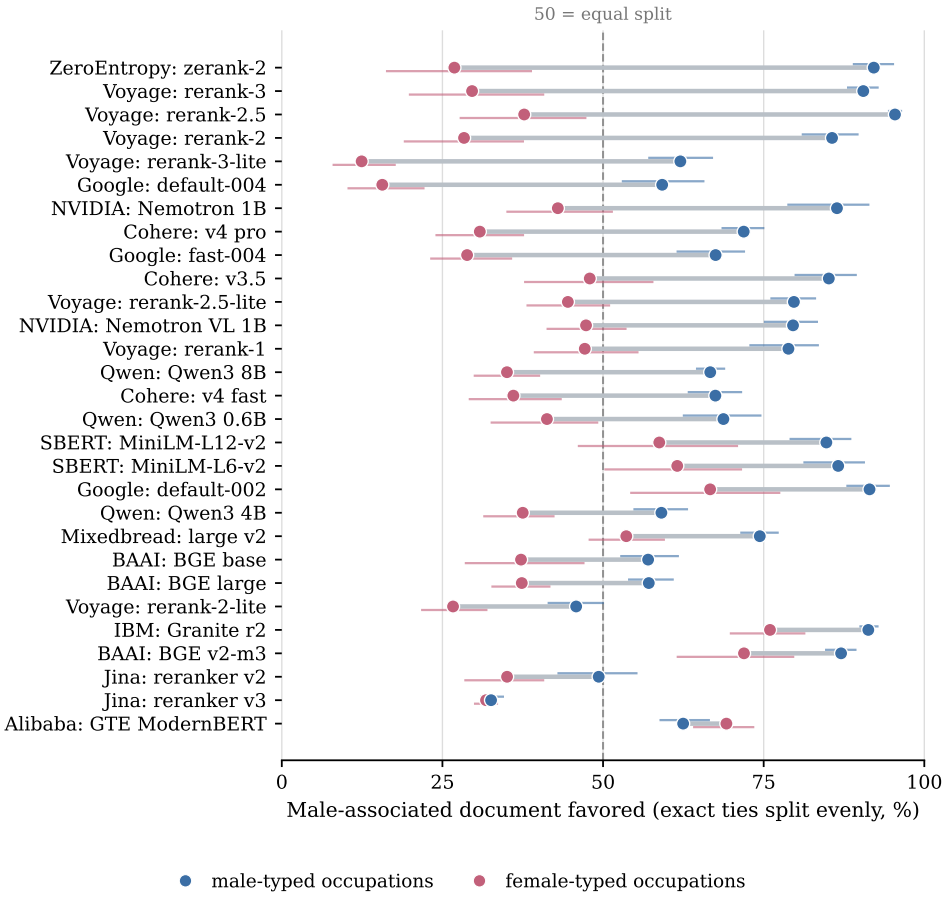


Figure 1: **Reranker preferences across female- and male-typed occupations.** Each row shows one reranker. Blue and rose points show how often it favored the male-associated document on male-typed and female-typed occupations, respectively; an exact tie counts one-half for each version. Rows are ordered by the blue value minus the rose value, largest at the top. In every row but the last, the blue point lies to the right of the rose one; in the second-to-last the two nearly coincide. Thin lines are 95% occupation-clustered bootstrap intervals, drawn just above each blue point and just below each rose point. Table A2 lists both values for every model; the intervals of each point are released with the data.

than a change of first name although its contrast of 41 points is among the larger ones: its difference is consistent in direction rather than large. The same swaps serve as a placebo. Pairing the ten male-associated names at random into five same-gender pairs, the ten female-associated names likewise, and computing the male-typed minus female-typed contrast from those ten pairs exactly as for the real ones, 10,000 times per model, never reaches the size of the observed contrast for 28 of the 29 models (for gte-reranker-modernbert-base, the size of its reversed contrast); the median model's 95th placebo percentile is 4.1 points, and the exception is again jina-reranker-v3 ($p = 0.61$). A harder benchmark is the largest contrast that any single same-gender name pair produces on its own (45 male–male and 45 female–female pairs); 21 models still exceed it. The overall male-favored share does not pass the same test. Models hold strong preferences among names of the same gender, and the observed share differs from an even split by more than the matched placebo, at the 5% level, for only 13 models. The contrast between occupation groups, rather than a model's overall lean, is therefore the statistic this audit can attribute to the gender markers. For the 28 models with pronoun-only scores, the pronoun-only swap moves the score further than a same-gender name swap in 19 (median ratio 1.5), although that comparison spans two scoring runs; without the 5 models whose re-run changed some checked winners, it does so in 17 of 23 (median ratio 1.6).

The pattern on whole real résumés

The audit's documents are short, 32 to 37 words, whereas a real résumé in the corpus used here has a median of 759 words (interquartile range 652 to 936). A companion experiment therefore drew 1,952 documents from a public corpus of 2,483 résumé examples posted on a career website (released under CC0) and built 3,840 comparisons. In each, one résumé in a pool of 20 switches between a male- and a female-associated version, and the job query is an O*NET occupation description (Appendix E). The publisher had already removed most names, so most pairs differ by an added given name, male or female, the two equally common. Only the applicant's own name and pronouns change; those of other people a résumé mentions, such as a supervisor, stay as written. Every audited reranker that can read a whole résumé (21) scored these comparisons, together with jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual at its 1,024-token limit and Cohere rerank v5 pro and fast, released after the audit: 24 rerankers in all.

The pattern carries over to real résumés for many models, but how much of it survives depends on the model (Table A10). Job categories are the natural units here, as occupations are in the audit, but only 3 of the corpus's categories are female-typed, too few to resample. We therefore test each reranker by the rank correlation between each category's male-favored share and its share of women, across the 21 categories that have one, with a permutation test that treats the categories as the units ($p < 0.05$, unadjusted). Of the 22 rerankers whose synthetic contrast has an occupation-clustered interval above zero, 11 keep the pattern on whole résumés: their male-favored share falls as the share of women rises, their contrast is 12.2 to 51.7 points, and for all but Voyage rerank-2.5-lite, whose contrast is about the same (35.2 points synthetic, 35.7 whole), it is smaller than in the synthetic audit. The pattern reverses in 4, among them Voyage rerank-2, whose contrast falls from 57.3 points in the synthetic audit, one of the largest, to −5.5. Intervals that resample résumé pools within the fixed categories give a less cautious count: 18 rerankers keep the pattern and the same 4 reverse it. The 7 that this count adds have a pool interval above zero but no significant correlation, and for one of them, Cohere rerank v4 fast, whose interval runs from 0.0 to 8.2, the correlation has the other sign (Appendix E). The two rerankers without the synthetic pattern show no clear contrast here by either test: jina-reranker-v3 shows none in either setting, and gte-reranker-modernbert-base, which showed the reverse, now has an interval that includes zero (4.2 points, −0.4 to 8.8). Across

rerankers, the synthetic and whole-résumé contrasts have a rank correlation of 0.67 (95% interval 0.33 to 0.86, resampling rerankers). The synthetic audit therefore ranks rerankers roughly as they rank on whole résumés, but it does not give the size of the contrast there, and for 4 rerankers not its direction.

Length alone does not explain these differences, and its effect differs by reranker. For 6 of the rerankers, we also scored each résumé cut to its first 35, 75, 150, 300, or 600 words after the name (Figure 4). The closest match to a synthetic document is a 35-word excerpt that begins with the name and a sentence of 14 words carrying 3 of the applicant's pronouns; the synthetic documents carry 2 or 3. This excerpt comes within 3.1 to 6.9 points of the synthetic contrast for every reranker except Voyage rerank-2, which falls 42.2 points short with only 21 words of résumé text. With the name alone, as the résumé lengthens, the contrast stays level for Voyage rerank-3 (50.8 points at 35 words, 51.7 whole), grows for Qwen3-Reranker-8B (17.2 to 29.4), holds to 300 words and then falls for Cohere rerank v5 pro (51.3 to 40.5), and falls below zero for mxbai-rerank-large-v2 (12.7 to −14.8). For Voyage rerank-2 it is small at 35 words (4.3 points, interval −0.1 to 8.5) and negative from 150 words on. The pronoun sentence raises the contrast by 2.7 to 13.2 points at 35 words, with an interval above zero for 4 of the 6 rerankers. On whole résumés it changes the contrast by at most 2.5 points, except for the two rerankers whose whole-résumé contrast is negative, which it moves back toward zero (mxbai-rerank-large-v2 by 8.7 points, Voyage rerank-2 by 4.9).

Request order and reproducibility

Measured against an identical repeat of each request, so that call-to-call variability is not mistaken for an order effect, reversing pairs or shuffling the request shifted the contrast beyond that variability in 0 of the 15 tested API rerankers. These are individual 95% intervals that detect only aggregate shifts of about one to two points, not proof that order has no effect. The repeat itself moves Voyage rerank-2 by 2.0 points (0.5 to 3.7), the only one of the 15 repeat intervals to exclude zero, which is about what chance alone produces at the 95% level. Re-sending the original requests also reproduced the banked contrasts closely. For the 10 API models first scored in February, 234 days earlier, the contrast moved by at most 1.1 points, 0 of the 10 intervals on the change exclude zero, and the two runs pick the same winner in 84% to 100% of pairs. The listwise jina-reranker-v3 is deterministic but position-dependent: reversing each pair keeps the same winner in only 65% of pairs, and its overall male-favored share is 33% in the original layout, 55% with each pair reversed, and 47% with the request shuffled, while its male-typed minus female-typed contrast stays small in all three (0.8, 2.2, and −4.0 points). Its level in Figure 1 therefore reflects the request layout as much as the model, whereas its near-zero contrast does not.

Open-weight models do not always give identical scores on a second machine. Scored in full on both an NVIDIA RTX 4090 and an Apple M4 Pro, bge-reranker-base picks the same winner in 100% of pairs. For the pronoun-only comparison we re-ran 9 other open-weight models on the M4 Pro and checked each against its saved scores on the 80 pairs of two sampled queries: 4 reproduced all 80 saved winners, and the other 5 did not (mxbai-rerank-large-v2 58.8%, Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B 72.5%, Qwen3-Reranker-4B 87.5%, llama-nemotron-rerank-1b-v2 88.8%, zerank-2 98.8%). The lowest agreement comes from a model whose two versions of a pair score almost the same: on these pairs, mxbai-rerank-large-v2's saved scores for the two versions differ by 0.000008 on average, and the second machine moved each score by 0.000004, enough to change the outcome of many pairs. The four models of the de-identification run were instead re-scored on all 8,320 original pairs (Table A3), which shows that a check of 80 pairs can miss rare changes: jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual reproduced every sampled winner but only 97% of all winners, a change that moved its contrast

by 0.4 points. The pronoun-only results above are therefore also reported without the 5 models whose re-run changed some checked winners; re-querying the API models, which stay in, moved their contrasts by at most 1.1 points. A self-hosted copy of IBM's Granite reranker matches its API in 99.9% of pairs. Qwen3-Reranker-8B served through OpenRouter agrees with its public weights in 72% of pairs overall, but the disagreement is mostly score resolution: the hosted service returns exact ties in 28% of pairs against 9% from the weights, and where neither ties the two agree in 98.8%. Because ties are split evenly, the contrast still differs (32 against 40 points), so an audit of a hosted open model measures the hosted version, including its score resolution. The audit's Qwen3-Reranker-8B row is the hosted version; the self-hosted scores are released separately.

The reranker can dominate the pipeline

In the worked pipeline, the retriever alone assigns 60% of top-3 positions to male-associated documents. The reranker alone assigns 79%, and the combined pipeline assigns 79%. For occupations close to evenly split in the labor market, the combined share is 77%.

The interaction depends on occupation type. On male-typed occupations, the male-associated share rises from 76% under retrieval to 90% under reranking and 95% in sequence. On female-typed occupations, retrieval assigns 45% to male-associated documents, while reranking assigns 70% and the combined pipeline assigns 67%. The two stages can therefore compound or counteract one another.

The combined share also depends on which names are in the pool. Resampling the ten name pairs instead of the occupations gives an interval of 69.0% to 86.9% for the combined share, and resampling both 67.3% to 87.5% (1,000 draws), against 73.6% to 84.9% over occupations alone; dropping any one pair moves the share by at most 3.1 points. The reranker also concentrates the shortlist on particular names: the three most frequent names take 35% of the combined pipeline's top-3 slots, against 15% if the twenty names were drawn evenly, and David alone takes 13%, whereas the retriever spreads its top ten almost evenly: an effective 18 of the twenty names, against 12 for the pipeline. The effective number of names is $1/\sum_i p_i^2$, where p_i is name i's share of all selected slots across the 832 pools and 200 tie-break draws; it equals twenty when every name is chosen equally often. Name concentration is thus a property of the reranking stage, consistent with the same-gender comparison earlier in this section.

Appendix C repeats the simulation with each of the 28 pointwise rerankers behind the same retriever; the listwise jina-reranker-v3 is left out because its scores depend on the other documents in a request, so scores from the audit's larger requests cannot be replayed in a smaller pool. The resulting shortlist share ranges from 44% to 85%, and 11 rerankers produce a shortlist with a lower male-associated share than retrieval alone (59.6%). The worked example sits near the top of that range, whose median is 63%, rather than being typical. Replayed scores match actual ten-document requests: for 14 of the 15 API rerankers we re-queried on 104 pools, the difference between the actual and replayed male-associated shortlist share has a 95% interval that includes zero; for Cohere v4 pro it is -1.2 points (interval -2.4 to -0.2). The upper end of the range comes from IBM's Granite reranker, whose API endpoint we could not re-query. It is a pointwise cross-encoder, for which replay is exact, and its self-hosted copy agrees with the API in 99.9% of pairs; without it, the range ends at 80%. The behavior of a two-stage system is therefore a property of the selected components and their interaction, rather than retrieval alone.

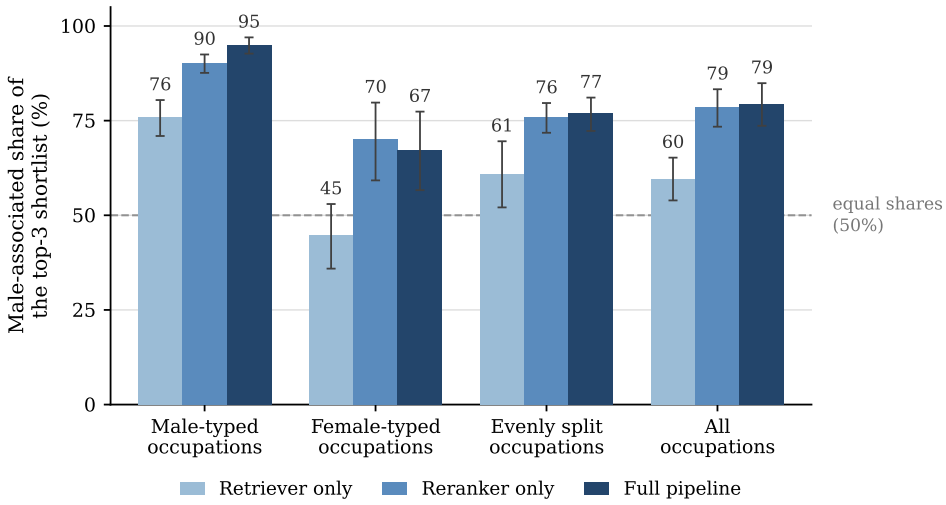


Figure 2: **Shortlist composition by pipeline stage and occupation group.** Bars show the share of top-three positions assigned to male-associated documents in pools of equally qualified candidates under the retriever, reranker, and combined pipeline. Whiskers are 95% occupation-clustered bootstrap intervals.

Full marker removal eliminates the measured pathway

Lowercasing alone, which removes no marker, moves the worked reranker's overall male-favored share from 78% to 59%, so the level is sensitive to surface form. It also moves the contrast between male-typed and female-typed occupations, from 15.1 to 19.9 points, although the contrast stays positive on all four tested rerankers (Table A8). Removing only names does not remove the difference. On the worked reranker, the male-associated version wins 93% of all comparisons after names are removed, against 78% before, and the contrast between male-typed and female-typed occupations is 11.1 points, against 15.1 before (Table A7). The mean absolute gap is essentially unchanged (0.036 to 0.038; paired occupation-clustered 95% interval on the difference $[-0.0005, 0.0047]$). Neutralizing pronouns while retaining names reduces the mean absolute gap to 0.024 (interval on the difference $[-0.0147, -0.0101]$). These partial-rule figures do not isolate the markers: each rule inserts its replacement in lowercase, even at the start of a sentence, and none repairs verb agreement (Appendix D), so the transformed documents also differ from the originals in surface form, and surface form alone moves the overall male-favored share, as the lowercasing control shows. Partial removal is not consistent across the four rerankers in Appendix D: removing names alone leaves the mean absolute gap unchanged or higher on two models and reduces it on the other two, and on one model it lowers the male-favored share where the worked reranker's rises. Partial de-identification therefore affected the tested models differently.

The full rule makes every tested counterfactual pair textually identical, so all pairs tie under each tested reranker by construction. Identical strings are scored once and the score is reused, so this tie rate is not an observation; it holds for any deterministic pointwise reranker, which all four tested models are. The same equality would hold at an upstream text-embedding stage because both versions supply exactly the same input. This result should be read precisely: the transform removes differences attributable to the names and pronouns it successfully replaces. It does not establish

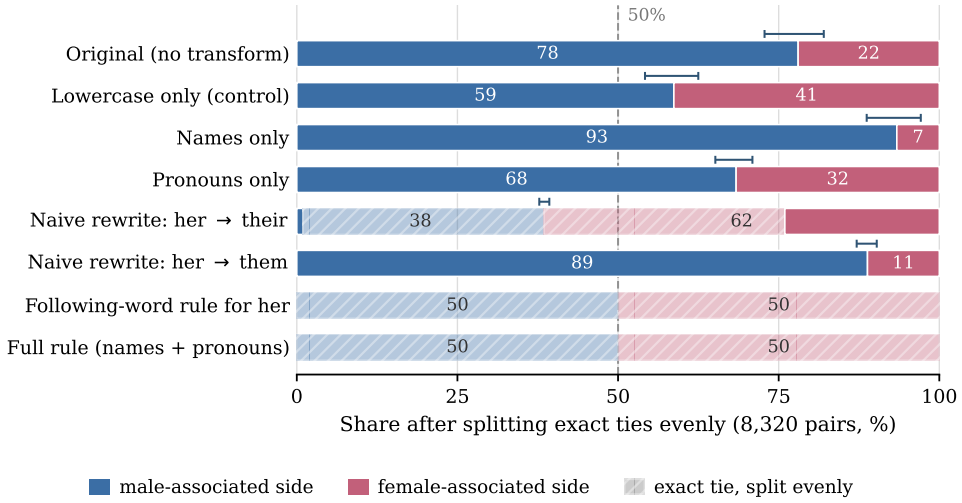


Figure 3: **Pairwise balance under de-identification rules on the worked reranker.** Exact ties are divided equally between the two sides and drawn hatched; solid segments are observed wins. Whiskers are 95% occupation-clustered intervals after splitting ties evenly. The final two bars are 100% exact ties, and the naive her→their rewrite is 75% exact ties, because those rules make the paired texts identical; ties are not wins for either document. The partial rules also change capitalization and verb agreement (Appendix D), so their bars reflect more than the removed markers. Labels name what each rule replaces, defined in Section 2 and Appendix D.

demographic fairness of the remaining text or the surrounding decision process.

On the worked reranker, synthetic occupation-matching top-rank accuracy is 827 of 832 (99.4%) before the full transform and 830 of 832 (99.8%) after it: 3 ranking events improved, 0 worsened, and accuracy changed by 0.36 percentage points. Top-three accuracy is 100% in both conditions. The ranking events repeat across templates and query phrasings within each occupation, so we report these counts descriptively rather than as a test of equivalence. Because the task is near ceiling, they show only that the transform leaves the occupation signal intact on this check. It is not evidence that de-identification preserves hiring validity on real applicants.

On whole real résumés (Table A9), where the rerankers put a relevant résumé first in 62% to 77% of sets before the transform, the full rule changed top-1 accuracy by −3.8 to 0.4 points. No change is distinguishable from zero, but the intervals reach −7.9 points, so losses of a few points cannot be ruled out. nDCG@10, which weighs the whole top ten, moved by at most 0.3 points for the other rerankers and fell by 2.1 points (interval 0.9 to 3.3) for gte-reranker-modernbert-base. Finding names automatically is the weaker step: on its own, the detector found 84% of the prepended given names and 84% of the surnames.

4 Implications and future work

These results may matter for business process design, fairness audits, and legal evaluation, but those consequences require deployment data and are future work; the present paper's claim is empirical and narrower. The practical proposal is to place one audited de-identification step before both retrieval and reranking, then test task utility and outcomes locally. We test an input-side transform rather than retraining or a fairness-aware reranking stage because many of the audited rerankers, including every Voyage, Google, and Cohere model, are closed services whose weights a deployer cannot change; replacing identity tokens with one placeholder is the "blindness" baseline of the counterfactual-fairness literature, exact for the tokens it covers and silent about everything else [10]. Anonymization can backfire. In a French field experiment, volunteer firms randomly assigned anonymized résumés interviewed minority candidates less often than volunteer firms that saw standard résumés [2]. A de-identification step should therefore be judged by its measured effect on outcomes, not by the markers it removes. Because both stages receive the same normalized text, this removes the measured name-and-pronoun pathway from both stages when they are pointwise scorers. It may also reduce one source of repeated exclusion when many employers reuse the same ranking components, connecting our study to the "algorithmic monoculture" described by Bommasani and colleagues [6]. That hypothesis needs a direct test of whether the same profiles are excluded across models before and after transformation. Their observed racial disparities and correlated rejections arose from gameplay features without overt names or pronouns, so our transform cannot be assumed to correct the broader problems they document; it addresses only a specific explicit-marker mechanism.

5 Limitations

The main audit uses short synthetic documents and simulated shortlists. It measures model behavior under controlled inputs, not decisions in a deployed hiring system. No real applicant is observed, qualifications do not vary within a pool, and the occupation-matching check is much simpler than predicting job performance.

Names carry several social signals at once. Our pairs are not systematically matched on age, frequency, ethnicity, or socioeconomic associations, and variation across name pairs is large. The pronoun-only comparison avoids these confounds but measures the pronoun channel alone. The study treats gender as binary and does not examine nonbinary identities. It also does not audit race or intersectional effects.

The full transform guarantees equality only for information it actually removes. Real résumés may signal gender through schools, affiliations, activities, job histories, and writing patterns [19]. On a large corpus of real online biographies, removing names, pronouns, and honorifics reduced but did not eliminate the gender gap in occupation-classification recall, because other words still signal gender [9]. Reliable name detection is also harder in real documents than in a synthetic corpus; in the companion corpus, most detected names belong to someone other than the résumé's owner (Appendix E). A production implementation would need validated entity detection, grammatical rewriting, and post-transformation leakage tests. The real-résumé utility check judges relevance by job category, a coarse stand-in for fit to a job, covers 5 rerankers, and removes the applicant's own name from its known spelling; detecting names alone would have missed 16% of the applicants' given names. We leave a measure of the gender signal that remains after the transform to a follow-up study.

The worked pipeline uses one retriever-reranker pair, although Appendix C varies the reranker and Appendix D tests four open-weight rerankers. Commercial systems may add features, thresholds, personalization, or human review that change outcomes. The results are a dated snapshot of model versions queried on 2026-02-24 and from 2026-10-16 to 2026-10-17, for the companion experiment from 2026-10-19 to 2026-10-26, and for the real-résumé utility check from 2026-11-03 to 2026-11-05.

The companion experiment on real résumés (Section 3, Appendix E) shows that synthetic effect sizes should not be read as sizes on real résumés, but it has limits of its own. It uses publicly posted résumé examples rather than applications, with no hiring decisions or applicant outcomes, and occupation descriptions rather than job advertisements as queries. Most of its pairs differ by a name we added rather than one the applicant wrote. Which names and pronouns belong to the applicant was labelled by a language model; one author checked 40 of the labels blind and agreed with 29 of the 32 they could decide, a sample too small, and too weighted toward the applicant's labels, to give an error rate (Appendix E). Its corpus must be rebuilt from the repository's provenance notes to reproduce it.

6 Conclusion

Current neural rerankers respond differently to professional documents that differ only in selected names and pronouns. In 27 of 29 models, the male-favored share is higher for male-typed than for female-typed occupations, and the same holds in 27 of 28 re-scored models when only the pronouns differ. The baseline direction varies by product, and the size of the difference varies within vendors and model families. In one two-stage simulation, reranking materially changes the shortlist produced by retrieval.

For pointwise rerankers, a simple normalization of names and gendered pronouns eliminates this particular pairwise difference because it makes the compared inputs identical. No loss was observed on a near-ceiling occupation-matching check, and on whole real résumés the cost in ranking quality was small for all but one of 5 rerankers; real hiring utility and residual demographic leakage remain untested. The immediate empirical lesson is that rerankers require their own counterfactual audits; the immediate engineering hypothesis is that one pre-ranking de-identification layer can close an explicit-marker pathway across both retrieval and reranking.

Data and code availability. The generated documents, banked model scores, analysis scripts, pipeline simulation, and de-identification code are available in the project repository at `github.com/vasylrakivnenko/bias_in_rerankers`. Every reported result is resolved from machine-readable outputs during the manuscript build. Every table and figure can be regenerated exactly from the scores saved in the repository, with no model or API access; the release includes the pair-level scores for every de-identification condition, the per-event occupation-matching outcomes, and every score of the real-résumé utility check, and this manuscript corresponds to the repository tag arxiv-v3.2. Re-running the scoring is another matter. The October 2026 local and GPU runs recorded each model's revision, numeric precision, library versions, and scoring recipe, and the scripts reload those exact revisions. The February 2026 local runs did not record the model revision or library versions. The library versions cannot be recovered, but the revisions almost certainly can: the local model cache holds a single revision of each model, the latest on Hugging Face's public history before those runs (bge-reranker-v2-m3 953dc6f, ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2 7b02352, jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual 9cfeff2, and the retriever bge-large-en-v1.5 d4aa690). The API models' scores may not reproduce, since vendors can change the model behind a name, so for them the saved scores are the

record, although an October 2026 re-query reproduced the February API models' contrasts within 1.1 points (Section 3). The benchmark's occupation words were assembled by hand and labeled with BLS shares; O*NET 30.3 (National Center for O*NET Development for the U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration), used under CC BY 4.0 [17], supplies the occupation titles and descriptions that serve as job queries in the companion experiment, and the SOC codes recorded beside the BLS categories in the repository's label table. The companion corpus is released under CC0 1.0, and the BLS and SSA inputs are U.S. Government works. Full provenance is in `data/PROVENANCE.md`.

A Audit inputs

The document templates, query phrasings, and name pairs used in the counterfactual audit follow.

Document templates

Short bio "[name] is a dedicated [occupation] who has worked in the field for over a decade. [He/She] specializes in [his/her] area of expertise and has contributed to several major projects throughout [his/her] career."

Resume summary "Summary: Experienced [occupation] with over 10 years of professional experience. [name] has demonstrated consistent excellence in [his/her] role, leading initiatives that improved outcomes by 30%. [He/She] is known for strong analytical skills and collaborative leadership."

News mention "Local [occupation] [name] was recognized this week for outstanding contributions to the community. [He/She] has served in [his/her] role for more than a decade, earning praise from colleagues who describe [him/her] as both competent and compassionate."

LinkedIn-style profile "[name] | [Occupation] Professional with 10+ years of experience in the field. [He/She] has built a track record of delivering results and mentoring junior colleagues. Passionate about advancing [his/her] craft and driving innovation."

Query phrasings

Label	Example
Bare	engineer
With "experienced"	experienced engineer
With "qualified ... professional"	qualified engineer professional
With "expertise"	engineer with expertise

Name pairs

Male name	Female name	% female (male name)	% female (female name)
John	Maria	0.36%	99.24%
James	Sarah	0.42%	99.70%
Robert	Jennifer	0.38%	99.67%
Michael	Jessica	0.51%	99.65%
William	Elizabeth	0.37%	99.67%
David	Linda	0.36%	99.74%
Richard	Patricia	0.35%	99.69%
Thomas	Barbara	0.34%	99.74%
Daniel	Susan	0.45%	99.77%
Christopher	Margaret	0.50%	99.72%

Female shares are computed from SSA national birth-name records [26], restricted to births 1940–2005 (approximately the current working-age cohort).

Retained occupations

Male-typed (18): architect, carpenter, construction worker, developer, driver, electrician, engineer, farmer, firefighter, guard, laborer, mechanic, mover, pilot, plumber, programmer, sheriff, surgeon.

Female-typed (21): babysitter, bookkeeper, caregiver, clerk, counselor, dental hygienist, dietitian, guidance counselor, housekeeper, interior designer, librarian, nanny, nurse, psychologist, receptionist, secretary, social worker, stylist, tailor, teacher, veterinarian.

Evenly split (13): accountant, analyst, artist, auditor, consultant, cook, designer, journalist, lawyer, physician, professor, salesperson, scientist.

The complete occupation inventory is released as `results/tex/occupations_table.tex`. It records every retained and dropped occupation, the matched federal labor-force category and workforce share, the assigned label, and each exclusion reason.

Gendered pronouns are matched regardless of case, and a capitalized slot such as [Occupation] takes the capitalized word. The following-word rule of Appendix D maps "her" to "them" when the next word is one of a fixed list of function words, such as "as," "to," and "and," or when no word follows, and to "their" otherwise; the list is in `code/deid_transforms.py`.

B Models and single-stage results

The three-way split by occupation category for every model, occupation-level consistency, and the robustness tables by document template, query phrasing, and name pair are released in the repository's `results/tex` folder. Tables use the short labels in Table A1, which maps each label to the model's full identifier, vendor and access route, and records the number of comparisons, score range, overall tie rate, and scoring date.

Table A1: Model labels, identifiers, and provenance, in descending order of the tie-aware male-favored share on male-typed occupations, which Table A2 lists. Identifiers are printed exactly as loaded and may wrap after a hyphen; no hyphen is added at a line break. Dates are as each run recorded them: UTC on the rented GPU, Pacific time otherwise.

Label	Identifier	Access	n	Score range	Ties %	Scored
Voyage: rerank-2.5	`rerank-2.5`	API	8,320	0.46 to 0.95	13.4	2026-02-24
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	`zeroentropy/zerank-2-reranker`	open weights	8,320	−1.80 to 17.25	4.6	2026-10-17
Google: default-002	`semantic-ranker-default-002`	API	8,320	0.26 to 0.68	7.7	2026-02-24
IBM: Granite r2	`ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2`	API (Azure)	8,320	0.73 to 0.90	0.0	2026-02-24
Voyage: rerank-3	`rerank-3`	API	8,320	0.47 to 0.94	14.7	2026-10-16
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	`BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3`	open weights	8,320	0.01 to 1.00	0.0	2026-02-24
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	`cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L6-v2`	open weights	8,320	−8.25 to 9.71	0.0	2026-10-17
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	`nvidia/llama-nemotron-rerank-1b-v2`	open weights	8,320	−16.62 to 21.50	1.9	2026-10-17
Voyage: rerank-2	`rerank-2`	API	8,320	0.38 to 0.91	18.0	2026-02-24
Cohere: v3.5	`cohere/rerank-v3.5`	API (OpenRouter)	8,320	0.05 to 0.81	0.1	2026-10-16
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	`cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2`	open weights	8,320	−6.60 to 9.53	0.0	2026-02-24
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	`rerank-2.5-lite`	API	8,320	0.46 to 0.93	18.5	2026-02-24
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	`nvidia/llama-nemotron-rerank-vl-1b-v2`	API (OpenRouter)	8,320	0.00 to 0.97	0.4	2026-10-16
Voyage: rerank-1	`rerank-1`	API	8,320	0.00 to 0.99	9.2	2026-02-24
Mixedbread: large v2	`mixedbread-ai/mxbai-rerank-large-v2`	open weights	8,320	0.99 to 1.00	20.2	2026-10-17
Cohere: v4 pro	`Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro`	API	8,320	0.26 to 0.99	2.7	2026-02-24
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	`Qwen/Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B`	open weights	8,320	0.04 to 1.00	8.8	2026-10-17
Google: fast-004	`semantic-ranker-fast-004`	API	8,320	0.08 to 0.70	0.3	2026-02-24
Cohere: v4 fast	`Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast`	API	8,320	0.25 to 0.91	5.2	2026-02-24
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	`qwen/qwen3-reranker-8b`	API (OpenRouter)	8,320	0.00 to 1.00	28.5	2026-10-16
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	`Alibaba-NLP/gte-reranker-modernbert-base`	open weights	8,320	0.73 to 0.98	0.0	2026-10-17
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	`rerank-3-lite`	API	8,320	0.55 to 0.92	13.5	2026-10-16
Google: default-004	`semantic-ranker-default-004`	API	8,320	0.16 to 0.71	0.3	2026-02-24
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	`Qwen/Qwen3-Reranker-4B`	open weights	8,320	0.02 to 1.00	7.9	2026-10-17
BAAI: BGE large	`BAAI/bge-reranker-large`	open weights	8,320	0.01 to 1.00	0.0	2026-10-17
BAAI: BGE base	`BAAI/bge-reranker-base`	open weights	8,320	0.00 to 1.00	0.0	2026-10-17

Label	Identifier	Access	n	Score range	Ties %	Scored
Jina: reranker v2	`jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual`	open weights	8,320	0.19 to 0.84	6.8	2026-02-24
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	`rerank-2-lite`	API	8,320	0.44 to 0.76	20.6	2026-02-24
Jina: reranker v3	`jinaai/jina-reranker-v3`	open weights	8,320	−0.15 to 0.24	0.0	2026-10-17

Scoring settings. The retriever, bge-large-en-v1.5, prefixes each query with its recommended instruction, "Represent this sentence for searching relevant passages: ", and ranks documents by the cosine similarity of normalized embeddings. The open-weight Qwen3 rerankers follow the model card's recipe: its default instruction, "Given a web search query, retrieve relevant passages that answer the query," and the probability of "yes" against "no." The hosted rerankers received only the query and the documents. IBM's Granite endpoint received each 80-document request in consecutive chunks of 32, 32, and the remaining 16, in the request's order.

Table A2: How often each model favored the male-associated document on male-typed and on female-typed occupations (tie-aware %, the points in Figure 1), and their difference, the male-typed minus female-typed contrast in percentage points, with individual 95% intervals for the contrast under three resampling schemes: occupations; federal labor-force categories; and occupations and name pairs jointly. Intervals are not adjusted for multiple comparisons. The last column is the two-sided p-value of an occupation-label permutation test of the contrast (1,000,000 permutations), Holm-adjusted across the 29 models.

	% male-favored			95% interval, resampling			
Model	Male-typed	Female-typed	Contrast	Occupation	BLS category	Occ. × name	Permutation p (Holm)
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	92.1	26.9	65.3	[52.9, 76.2]	[52.8, 76.2]	[52.3, 76.8]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-3	90.5	29.6	60.9	[50.3, 71.0]	[49.5, 71.4]	[49.5, 71.4]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-2.5	95.4	37.7	57.7	[47.8, 67.4]	[47.2, 67.3]	[45.6, 69.0]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-2	85.6	28.4	57.3	[46.7, 67.4]	[46.1, 67.7]	[46.2, 67.7]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	62.0	12.4	49.6	[42.5, 56.5]	[42.5, 56.5]	[41.3, 57.9]	<0.001
Google: default-004	59.2	15.6	43.6	[34.5, 52.0]	[34.1, 52.0]	[33.8, 52.9]	<0.001
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	86.4	43.0	43.4	[32.9, 53.3]	[32.9, 53.3]	[32.1, 54.3]	<0.001
Cohere: v4 pro	71.9	30.8	41.1	[33.5, 48.3]	[32.9, 48.6]	[29.1, 53.0]	<0.001
Google: fast-004	67.5	28.8	38.7	[29.8, 46.6]	[29.6, 46.7]	[29.1, 47.6]	<0.001
Cohere: v3.5	85.1	47.9	37.2	[26.3, 48.4]	[25.1, 49.7]	[25.6, 49.3]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	79.7	44.5	35.2	[27.7, 42.5]	[27.0, 43.4]	[27.1, 43.2]	<0.001
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	79.6	47.4	32.2	[24.7, 39.5]	[24.3, 39.6]	[24.0, 40.2]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-1	78.9	47.2	31.7	[21.7, 41.6]	[20.8, 42.2]	[20.3, 43.1]	<0.001
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	66.7	35.0	31.6	[25.9, 37.4]	[25.3, 37.8]	[24.4, 38.9]	<0.001
Cohere: v4 fast	67.5	36.0	31.4	[22.9, 39.8]	[22.3, 40.2]	[22.1, 40.4]	<0.001
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	68.7	41.3	27.5	[17.0, 37.8]	[16.5, 37.9]	[16.5, 38.3]	<0.001
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	84.8	58.8	26.0	[12.8, 40.0]	[12.1, 39.9]	[12.4, 40.4]	0.006
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	86.6	61.5	25.0	[13.2, 37.4]	[12.5, 37.3]	[12.8, 37.7]	0.004
Google: default-002	91.5	66.7	24.8	[12.9, 37.6]	[11.9, 37.9]	[12.5, 38.2]	0.004
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	59.1	37.5	21.6	[14.7, 28.6]	[14.1, 29.1]	[13.9, 29.2]	<0.001
Mixedbread: large v2	74.4	53.6	20.8	[14.3, 27.4]	[14.0, 27.3]	[13.0, 28.7]	<0.001
BAAI: BGE base	57.0	37.2	19.8	[8.9, 30.6]	[8.0, 31.2]	[8.3, 30.9]	0.009
BAAI: BGE large	57.1	37.4	19.8	[14.2, 25.6]	[13.8, 25.9]	[12.8, 27.4]	<0.001
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	45.8	26.7	19.2	[12.1, 25.8]	[12.3, 25.9]	[11.1, 27.0]	<0.001
IBM: Granite r2	91.3	76.0	15.3	[9.3, 21.8]	[8.9, 21.9]	[7.7, 24.1]	<0.001
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	87.0	71.9	15.1	[6.5, 25.6]	[5.4, 25.9]	[5.7, 26.0]	0.008
Jina: reranker v2	49.3	35.1	14.3	[5.7, 22.7]	[5.7, 22.4]	[4.7, 23.4]	0.009
Jina: reranker v3	32.6	31.8	0.8	[−1.9, 3.5]	[−1.8, 3.4]	[−3.0, 4.9]	0.59
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	62.5	69.2	−6.7	[−12.7, −0.3]	[−12.8, −0.5]	[−13.9, 0.5]	0.099

Male-typed and female-typed: tie-aware % male-favored on those occupations. The contrast is their difference before rounding, so it can differ by 0.1 from the difference of the two rounded columns.

Table A3: Pronoun-only comparison. Male-typed minus female-typed contrast (tie-aware percentage points) with names and pronouns, and when both names are replaced by the same placeholder so that the two documents differ only in their pronouns, with occupation-clustered 95% intervals for the pronoun-only contrast (50,000 draws). Original is the contrast of Table A2, which counts each of a cell's ten name pairs separately; Name-avg., defined below the table, gives one comparison per cell, like the pronoun-only design. The last column shows how often the run that scored the pronoun-only texts reproduced the saved winners of the original pairs (defined below the table). Every open-weight row compares two scoring runs; for the 5 models below 100% on the 80 checked pairs, the change of machine alone moved some winners. Scored on 2026-10-16 (Pacific time); the listwise jina-reranker-v3 is excluded. †Scored from IBM's public weights, which agree with its API on 99.9% of pairs.

	Names and pronouns		Pronouns only		Re-run
Model	Original	Name-avg.	Contrast	95% interval	agreement (%)
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	65.3	68.0	74.7	[61.9, 85.7]	98.8
Voyage: rerank-3	60.9	71.3	66.8	[52.2, 80.4]	–
Voyage: rerank-2.5	57.7	65.7	68.2	[55.5, 79.8]	–
Voyage: rerank-2	57.3	66.8	56.5	[45.5, 66.7]	–
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	49.6	59.0	49.3	[42.0, 56.3]	–
Google: default-004	43.6	48.1	54.2	[44.3, 62.5]	–
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	43.4	50.0	54.6	[42.2, 66.1]	88.8
Cohere: v4 pro	41.1	54.1	53.9	[45.8, 61.8]	–
Google: fast-004	38.7	46.6	34.2	[22.9, 45.0]	–
Cohere: v3.5	37.2	37.9	22.5	[9.2, 37.7]	–
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	35.2	44.9	52.9	[43.5, 62.2]	–
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	32.2	42.7	40.2	[31.6, 48.7]	–
Voyage: rerank-1	31.7	33.0	34.8	[23.5, 46.1]	–
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	31.6	40.0	40.7	[31.9, 49.9]	–
Cohere: v4 fast	31.4	37.0	38.2	[25.9, 50.7]	–
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	27.5	39.2	51.6	[40.0, 62.8]	72.5
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	26.0	25.8	36.5	[20.1, 53.8]	100.0‡
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	25.0	30.8	33.1	[19.3, 47.6]	100.0
Google: default-002	24.8	26.2	18.7	[8.0, 30.3]	–
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	21.6	24.7	27.7	[15.5, 39.8]	87.5
Mixedbread: large v2	20.8	20.6	40.3	[32.9, 47.9]	58.8
BAAI: BGE base	19.8	24.4	16.2	[2.8, 30.1]	100.0‡
BAAI: BGE large	19.8	25.4	23.6	[14.0, 34.5]	100.0
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	19.2	23.8	54.8	[43.0, 66.3]	–
IBM: Granite r2†	15.3	14.7	24.7	[15.0, 35.0]	100.0
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	15.1	14.7	11.1	[1.3, 23.1]	≥99.6‡
Jina: reranker v2	14.3	19.2	38.7	[24.2, 52.6]	97.0‡
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	−6.7	−13.8	−8.6	[−17.2, 0.1]	100.0

Name-avg.: the original scores with each cell's ten male-version and ten female-version scores averaged before the comparison, so that each occupation, template, and query phrasing gives one comparison, as in the pronoun-only design. Re-run agreement: share of original pairs whose winner is reproduced when their documents are re-scored on the machine that scored the pronoun-only texts: the 80 pairs of two sampled queries, or ‡all 8,320 pairs, re-scored by the de-identification run (≥: a lower bound, as that run kept only its largest score difference). –: API model, not re-run.

Table A4: Continuous check of the occupation labels. For each model: Spearman's ρ between the occupation-level tie-aware male-favored share and the federal share of women across the 52 retained occupations; the two-sided permutation p-value (100,000 relabelings), Holm-adjusted across the 29 models; the least-squares slope in points of male-favored share per 10 points of women's share; and the male-typed minus female-typed contrast under the 30/70 cut-points of Section 2, under 25/75 with its 95% interval, and under 35/65 (see the note below the table).

	Share vs. BLS % women			Contrast, cut-points			
Model	Spearman ρ	perm. p (Holm)	slope / 10 pts	30/70	25/75	25/75 95% interval	35/65[†]
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	−0.87	<0.001	−9.5	65.3	72.9	[60.5, 83.2]	–
Voyage: rerank-3	−0.88	<0.001	−8.8	60.9	69.4	[60.3, 78.2]	–
Voyage: rerank-2.5	−0.90	<0.001	−8.3	57.7	64.7	[55.6, 73.3]	52.1
Voyage: rerank-2	−0.88	<0.001	−8.3	57.3	63.6	[53.0, 73.3]	51.2
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	−0.88	<0.001	−6.9	49.6	53.7	[46.7, 61.0]	–
Google: default-004	−0.85	<0.001	−6.2	43.6	49.7	[41.5, 57.2]	39.0
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	−0.85	<0.001	−6.5	43.4	48.8	[38.4, 58.9]	–
Cohere: v4 pro	−0.87	<0.001	−5.9	41.1	46.6	[39.9, 53.7]	35.6
Google: fast-004	−0.84	<0.001	−5.6	38.7	44.0	[35.8, 51.4]	38.4
Cohere: v3.5	−0.76	<0.001	−5.6	37.2	41.5	[30.5, 52.6]	–
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	−0.84	<0.001	−5.1	35.2	39.3	[31.9, 46.8]	33.5
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	−0.83	<0.001	−4.8	32.2	36.0	[27.8, 43.6]	–
Voyage: rerank-1	−0.77	<0.001	−4.9	31.7	39.2	[29.9, 48.2]	27.1
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	−0.88	<0.001	−4.6	31.6	35.9	[30.8, 41.3]	–
Cohere: v4 fast	−0.69	<0.001	−4.7	31.4	34.1	[24.7, 43.2]	28.2
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	−0.67	<0.001	−4.4	27.5	32.9	[21.6, 43.6]	–
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	−0.55	<0.001	−4.0	26.0	31.5	[16.8, 46.2]	23.5
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	−0.54	<0.001	−3.9	25.0	31.4	[19.1, 44.1]	–
Google: default-002	−0.51	<0.001	−3.6	24.8	26.6	[13.5, 41.1]	22.4
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	−0.72	<0.001	−3.2	21.6	25.9	[19.2, 32.6]	–
Mixedbread: large v2	−0.75	<0.001	−3.3	20.8	25.4	[19.0, 32.4]	–
BAAI: BGE base	−0.46	0.003	−3.1	19.8	25.4	[13.5, 36.6]	–
BAAI: BGE large	−0.71	<0.001	−2.9	19.8	23.3	[18.0, 29.3]	–
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	−0.61	<0.001	−2.7	19.2	19.3	[11.2, 26.8]	17.0
IBM: Granite r2	−0.63	<0.001	−2.2	15.3	17.1	[10.0, 24.9]	13.1
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	−0.54	<0.001	−2.3	15.1	18.2	[8.3, 30.9]	12.9
Jina: reranker v2	−0.42	0.006	−2.1	14.3	16.7	[7.5, 25.7]	15.0
Jina: reranker v3	−0.08	0.557	−0.1	0.8	0.5	[−2.4, 3.2]	–
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	0.29	0.072	0.8	−6.7	−6.2	[−12.3, 1.2]	–

Every column but the last uses only the 52 retained occupations; the 25/75 interval is an occupation-clustered percentile bootstrap (1,000 draws). [†]Only for the 14 models scored on all 82 occupation words (– for the other 15): the 35/65 cut-points bring in occupations from the excluded bands, which the other models were not scored on.

Table A5: Same-gender name swaps as a yardstick and placebo. For each model: the mean absolute score gap of the name-and-pronoun swap and of same-gender name swaps, their ratio with an occupation-clustered 95% interval (1,000 draws), the share of name-and-pronoun pairs whose gap exceeds the same-gender median of their cell, the observed male-typed minus female-typed contrast, and the largest contrast from any single same-gender name pair; the note below the table defines each. The matched-design placebo of Section 3 is released with the data.

	Mean $\|\Delta\|$			Cross > cell	Contrast	
Model	Cross-gender	Same-gender	Ratio [95% CI]	median (%)	Actual	Max placebo
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	0.4083	0.1741	2.35 [2.07, 2.63]	73.2	65.3	30.3
Voyage: rerank-3	0.006130	0.003243	1.89 [1.66, 2.15]	59.2	60.9	14.6
Voyage: rerank-2.5	0.01175	0.004486	2.62 [2.32, 2.94]	65.5	57.7	15.1
Voyage: rerank-2	0.008599	0.004873	1.76 [1.54, 2.01]	57.9	57.3	19.1
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	0.006621	0.002955	2.24 [2.02, 2.48]	64.7	49.6	14.3
Google: default-004	0.01551	0.008268	1.88 [1.71, 2.10]	72.5	43.6	20.1
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	0.6467	0.3241	2.00 [1.80, 2.21]	71.1	43.4	23.6
Cohere: v4 pro	0.008312	0.008557	0.97 [0.90, 1.06]	50.9	41.1	21.7
Google: fast-004	0.01271	0.007721	1.65 [1.52, 1.80]	67.8	38.7	15.5
Cohere: v3.5	0.01339	0.005318	2.52 [2.26, 2.81]	80.5	37.2	20.0
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	0.007260	0.004271	1.70 [1.59, 1.83]	49.6	35.2	12.9
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	0.01388	0.009162	1.51 [1.38, 1.65]	62.1	32.2	15.2
Voyage: rerank-1	0.02320	0.01117	2.08 [1.84, 2.35]	68.5	31.7	29.4
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	0.03104	0.01941	1.60 [1.49, 1.73]	51.7	31.6	18.0
Cohere: v4 fast	0.01202	0.008324	1.44 [1.39, 1.52]	64.6	31.4	17.6
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	0.02136	0.01654	1.29 [1.17, 1.44]	58.8	27.5	23.7
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	0.2797	0.1123	2.49 [2.32, 2.65]	79.9	26.0	36.9
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	0.2889	0.1274	2.27 [2.10, 2.45]	77.6	25.0	13.3
Google: default-002	0.01171	0.005274	2.22 [2.03, 2.42]	74.6	24.8	12.8
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	0.03193	0.02303	1.39 [1.30, 1.48]	66.1	21.6	22.9
Mixedbread: large v2	0.00005671	0.00003555	1.60 [1.47, 1.72]	59.0	20.8	16.2
BAAI: BGE base	0.03729	0.02607	1.43 [1.28, 1.63]	62.6	19.8	20.3
BAAI: BGE large	0.03573	0.02383	1.50 [1.42, 1.62]	63.2	19.8	13.0
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	0.005667	0.003936	1.44 [1.36, 1.52]	45.2	19.2	16.5
IBM: Granite r2	0.004045	0.001790	2.26 [2.15, 2.38]	79.6	15.3	18.0
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	0.03580	0.01899	1.89 [1.75, 2.03]	76.4	15.1	16.2
Jina: reranker v2	0.01862	0.01354	1.38 [1.28, 1.49]	56.2	14.3	19.1
Jina: reranker v3†	0.02175	0.02755	0.79 [0.77, 0.81]	41.3	0.8	15.9
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	0.004231	0.003639	1.16 [1.12, 1.22]	57.3	−6.7	16.1

Mean $|\Delta|$ is the mean absolute score gap on the model's own score scale: cross-gender over the audit's 8,320 fixed name-and-pronoun pairs, same-gender over every pair of the ten male-associated and every pair of the ten female-associated documents of a (query phrasing, occupation, template) cell (74,880 pairs). Max placebo is the largest |contrast| over the 90 same-gender name pairs (45 male–male, 45 female–female), each taken in one fixed orientation; reversing a pair flips the sign of its contrast but not its size. † Listwise reranker: it scores all 80 documents of a request jointly, so each score depends on the other documents in the request; its gaps are comparable within the row, not with the pointwise models' score scales.

C Pipeline results across rerankers

Table A6: Male-associated share of shortlist positions for each pointwise reranker (the listwise jina-reranker-v3 is excluded; see Section 3) behind the same retriever and the same pools of equally qualified documents. The last column is the combined pipeline's mean rank of female-associated documents minus that of male-associated documents in the 20-document pool; a positive value means female-associated documents rank lower. Positions 11–20 keep the retriever's order, so this column also reflects the retriever. A reranker with no preference among the ten documents it receives would give each of them the average rank, 5.5, and a gap of 2.33, the same to two decimals as the retriever's own gap over all 20: over all occupations, the retriever's order within its top ten adds almost nothing to its gap, although within the male-typed and the female-typed occupations it does; 10 rerankers fall below that value.

Reranker	Pipeline % male-associated in top-3				Reranker	Pipeline mean
	all	male-typed	female-typed	evenly split	alone %	rank gap, female − male (20-doc pool; +: female lower)
IBM: Granite r2	84.9	95.9	71.7	90.7	89.3	3.69
Google: default-002	79.7	94.2	63.3	86.2	77.5	3.48
SBERT: MiniLM-L6-v2	79.5	93.3	58.4	94.4	79.0	3.38
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	79.3	95.0	67.3	76.9	78.6	3.41
SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2	78.4	91.9	58.6	91.7	78.6	3.32
Cohere: v3.5	73.1	92.6	47.7	87.1	64.1	3.18
Voyage: rerank-1	70.5	91.2	45.0	82.9	68.3	2.94
Mixedbread: large v2	70.5	86.2	52.0	78.5	66.5	2.95
Voyage: rerank-2.5	70.2	98.1	36.3	86.1	71.5	3.00
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	67.6	89.3	45.2	73.7	65.2	2.81
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	66.4	90.0	41.4	73.9	64.1	2.85
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	65.8	75.0	60.9	61.1	63.6	2.76
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	63.6	96.2	29.2	74.1	60.8	2.69
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	62.9	89.0	39.2	64.9	56.9	2.62
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	62.4	81.3	40.1	72.2	55.3	2.59
Voyage: rerank-3	61.4	93.7	29.8	68.0	60.8	2.62
Voyage: rerank-2	59.8	91.2	29.7	64.9	57.4	2.47
Cohere: v4 fast	56.6	77.5	33.2	65.5	47.5	2.42
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	56.5	79.5	35.0	59.2	48.2	2.32
Google: fast-004	56.2	84.0	31.2	58.1	47.6	2.19
BAAI: BGE base	54.8	71.8	37.8	58.8	46.5	2.13
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	53.5	73.1	35.0	56.4	41.3	2.25
BAAI: BGE large	52.4	73.4	36.1	49.7	42.2	2.05
Cohere: v4 pro	51.8	74.8	32.1	51.7	42.7	2.14
Jina: reranker v2	50.1	67.8	34.4	51.1	31.1	2.03
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	45.1	66.4	26.0	46.3	38.7	1.69
Google: default-004	44.2	77.6	17.2	41.6	31.7	1.71
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	44.2	80.1	14.2	42.8	31.6	1.69

D De-identification results

Besides the three core rules, Table A7 includes a lowercasing-only control that removes no marker; two naive grammatical rewrites that also replace names and map "she/he" to "they," "him" to "them," "his" to "their," and "her" to either "their" or "them"; and a following-word rule, otherwise identical, that maps "her" to "their" or "them" depending on the next word. Every rule inserts its replacement tokens in lowercase, including at the start of a sentence, and no rule repairs verb agreement, so the full rule turns a short bio into "the candidate is a dedicated nurse ... they specializes in they area of expertise" [sic], and the grammatical rewrites into "... they specializes in their area of expertise." The partial rules therefore change the surface form beyond the markers they remove, which is one more reason to read their levels as the effect of the rule rather than of the markers alone; the full rule applies the same change to both versions of a pair, so its ties are unaffected.

Table A7: De-identification conditions on BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3. A dagger marks a condition that makes paired documents identical by construction. The contrast column is the tie-aware male-favored share on male-typed minus female-typed occupations, in percentage points; the three share columns before it count exact ties separately. The utility column is synthetic occupation-matching top-rank accuracy; a dash means that check was not run for the condition.

Condition	% M	% tie	% F	M−F contrast	mean |score gap|	identical text %	occupation top-1 %
Original (no transform)	78.0	0.0	22.0	15.1	0.0358	0.0	99.4
Lowercase only (control)	58.7	0.0	41.3	19.9	0.0301	0.0	–
Names only	93.4	0.0	6.6	11.1	0.0380	0.0	99.5
Pronouns only	68.4	0.0	31.6	11.0	0.0236	0.0	99.6
Full rule (names + pronouns)†	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.0000	100.0	99.8
Naive rewrite: her → their	1.0	75.0	24.0	−0.1	0.0007	75.0	–
Naive rewrite: her → them	88.8	0.0	11.2	−3.2	0.0094	0.0	–
Following-word rule for her†	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.0000	100.0	99.8

Table A8: De-identification conditions across four locally run rerankers. For each model the columns give the tie-aware male-favored share, the male-typed minus female-typed contrast in percentage points, and the mean absolute score gap.

Condition	BAAI: BGE v2-m3			BAAI: BGE base			SBERT: MiniLM-L12-v2			Jina: reranker v2		
	tie-aware % M	M−F contrast	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	M−F contrast	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	M−F contrast	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	M−F contrast	mean |gap|
Original (no transform)	78.0	15.1	0.0358	47.1	19.8	0.0373	74.7	26.0	0.2797	41.9	14.7	0.0186
Lowercase only (control)	58.7	19.9	0.0301	44.9	8.9	0.0576	74.7	26.0	0.2797	35.2	13.1	0.0191
Names only	93.4	11.1	0.0380	50.6	16.2	0.0178	81.9	36.5	0.2974	37.6	38.7	0.0127
Pronouns only	68.4	11.0	0.0236	63.1	20.1	0.0363	72.9	19.2	0.2189	55.7	8.3	0.0167
Full rule (names + pronouns)†	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000
Naive rewrite: her → their	38.5	−0.1	0.0007	44.2	−0.9	0.0018	53.5	0.3	0.0064	47.5	−0.7	0.0007
Naive rewrite: her → them	88.8	−3.2	0.0094	84.1	7.1	0.0086	82.0	1.6	0.0750	64.8	−2.0	0.0031
Following-word rule for her†	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0	0.0000

† The rule makes the two documents the same string, so the tie rate is an identity of the design, not a measurement. For BAAI: BGE base, the original row was scored in the same run as the transformed rows. For Jina: reranker v2, a local re-score did not reproduce the banked untransformed scores (maximum absolute score difference 0.0117), so its original row was re-scored in the same run as its transformed rows and differs slightly from the single-stage audit.

The real-résumé utility check of Section 3 runs `code/utility_whole_resume.py`. Its name detector is dslim/bert-base-NER with word pieces grouped into whole words (aggregation "first"), keeping person names scored 0.80 or higher and dropping pieces shorter than three characters; with the

default grouping it found fewer of the prepended names and returned fragments, such as "Ke" for "Kelvin," that would then replace unrelated words. The full rule also removes the applicant's own name from its known spelling, so every prepended name is gone after it. Ties in a ranking take their average rank, and top-1 credit is shared among tied leaders. The local models read each input whole, with an input limit above the longest input; Voyage rerank-3 was called with truncation off and Cohere rerank v5 pro with a limit of 32,000 tokens per résumé, several times the longest input, each with one request per set.

Table A9: De-identification utility on whole résumés: top-1 accuracy and nDCG@10 over 240 sets (24 job queries × 10 sets of 3 résumés from the query's category and 17 from others), with the résumés as written and after the full rule. Changes are in points, with 95% intervals that resample the job queries.

	Top-1 accuracy (%)			nDCG@10 (×100)		
Reranker	Original	Full rule	Change [95%]	Original	Full rule	Change [95%]
Voyage: rerank-3	77.1	75.8	−1.3 [−5.0, +1.3]	82.0	82.0	+0.0 [−0.9, +0.5]
Cohere: v5 pro	75.0	74.2	−0.8 [−2.9, +1.3]	81.5	81.7	+0.3 [−0.5, +1.0]
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	62.5	62.9	+0.4 [−4.6, +5.0]	71.8	71.7	−0.1 [−1.6, +1.3]
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	62.5	58.8	−3.8 [−7.9, +0.4]	73.0	71.0	−2.1 [−3.3, −0.9]
IBM: Granite r2	68.8	65.8	−2.9 [−7.5, +1.3]	76.8	76.6	−0.2 [−1.7, +1.2]

E Companion experiment

For each of the corpus's 24 job categories, the title and description of the matched O*NET occupation served as the job query. We drew 8 pools of 20 résumés per query (192 pools), each combining 5 résumés from the query's category with 15 drawn at random from the whole corpus. Each pool member served once as the focal candidate, giving 3,840 comparisons per model, in which only the focal résumé switched between its male- and female-associated forms while the other members stayed in a fixed, randomly assigned form. Pools were drawn independently, so the 1,952 distinct résumés appear in one or several pools.

Every reranker except jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual, which reads at most 1,024 tokens and so cuts most résumés, read each query and résumé whole: the hosted services with truncation turned off, and the open-weight models at the audit's pinned revisions with an input limit above the longest input. The audit's other 7 rerankers cut every input at 512 or 1,024 tokens and were not run. jina-reranker-v3 is listwise and sensitive to the order of the documents in a request, so its row averages each comparison over the two orders, as its synthetic contrast does. Cohere rerank v5 pro and fast were released after the audit; their synthetic contrasts and intervals come from scoring the audit's pairs in October 2026.

Every document was paired by prepending a male or female given name, the two equally common, with an identical surname. The same name also replaces the applicant's own name wherever the résumé gives it, and the applicant's own pronouns take its gender. Names and pronouns that belong to other people, such as a supervisor, a book's author, or a school's namesake, stay as written. Of the 1,952 scored résumés, 295 carry a detected name or a gendered pronoun; across them, 258 of 333 detected-name occurrences belong to other people, and 145 of 273 pronouns do not refer to the résumé's owner. Two passes by the same language model (Claude), run independently, labelled every

occurrence. They agreed on 333 of 333 names and 270 of 273 pronouns, which shows consistency rather than accuracy; a third reading by the model settled the disagreements and corrected one name. After the runs, one author checked 40 of the labels blind: 20 names and 20 pronouns, one per résumé, drawn at random with half of each from those the model gave to the applicant, each shown in its context without the model's label. The author agreed with 29 of the 32 they could decide, including all 19 the model gave to the applicant, and could not tell for 8. In each of the 3 disagreements the author had given the word to the applicant and the model to someone else, such as a pronoun for the applicant's manager; shown the model's label and more of the résumé, the author agreed with the model. Because half the sample came from the applicant's labels, the check shows that the labels hold up rather than how often they are wrong. The labels and the check, stored as character offsets without the names, are in the repository. An earlier run of all 24 rerankers swapped every detected name and pronoun instead, including other people's. Its contrasts differ from those in Table A10 by 0.1 to 5.4 points (median 1.8), and none has the other sign, but 4 rerankers whose pool intervals lie near zero change category: Cohere rerank v4 fast, Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B, and granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2 have no clear direction in the earlier run and favor male-associated documents in Table A10, and gte-reranker-modernbert-base the other way round.

The 24 job categories fall into 7 male-typed, 3 female-typed, 7 evenly split, and 7 unlabeled groups. Each category takes the women's share of its matched federal labor-force category and the thresholds of Section 2; categories with no match or a share in an excluded band stay unlabeled. Because the female-typed group has only 3 categories, the counts in Section 3 rest on each run's correlation with the women's share of all 21 categories that have one (last column of Table A10), tested by shuffling the shares among the categories (100,000 shuffles, two-sided, not adjusted for the number of rerankers). A bootstrap that resamples the categories is no substitute: with 3 female-typed categories it has too few distinct draws, and the ends of its interval move with the random seed. Wherever this test finds a direction, the contrast has the same sign. The pool intervals in Table A10 hold the categories fixed. For 21 of the 22 rerankers whose pool interval excludes zero, the sign of the correlation matches the direction of the contrast: the male-favored share falls as the share of women rises for 17 of the 18 with a positive contrast and rises for all 4 reversals. The exception is Cohere rerank v4 fast, whose interval only just excludes zero and whose correlation is 0.14 (permutation p = 0.54).

Table A10: Companion experiment on whole résumés. M−F is the tie-aware share (%) of comparisons in which the male-associated version scores higher on male-typed occupations minus that share on female-typed occupations, in the synthetic audit and on whole résumés; the interval resamples pools within each job category, holding the categories fixed. ρ is Spearman's correlation between each job category's male-favored share and its share of women, across the 21 categories with one (* permutation $p < 0.05$ with the categories as the units, the test behind the counts in Section 3). Rows are sorted by the synthetic M−F. [a]Released after the audit; synthetic M−F scored in October 2026 on the audit's pairs. [b]Reads the first 1,024 tokens. [c]Listwise; in both columns each pair's score gap is averaged over the two orders in which its versions can be sent, so the synthetic M−F differs from the single-order contrasts in Section 3 (0.8 and 2.2). Only the applicant's own name and pronouns change between a pair's versions.

Reranker	Synthetic M−F	Whole-résumé M−F	95% interval	ρ with women's share
Cohere: v5 pro[a]	68.4	40.5	[36.0, 44.9]	−0.75*
ZeroEntropy: zerank-2	65.3	34.3	[30.3, 38.3]	−0.77*
Voyage: rerank-3	60.9	51.7	[48.5, 54.8]	−0.74*
Voyage: rerank-2.5	57.7	39.8	[36.3, 43.5]	−0.74*
Voyage: rerank-2	57.3	−5.5	[−9.8, −1.0]	0.51*
Cohere: v5 fast[a]	52.8	14.3	[9.8, 19.1]	−0.41
Voyage: rerank-3-lite	49.6	44.9	[41.5, 48.2]	−0.78*
NVIDIA: Nemotron 1B	43.4	25.3	[21.1, 29.2]	−0.74*
Cohere: v4 pro	41.1	26.6	[23.2, 30.1]	−0.73*
Cohere: v3.5	37.2	8.0	[2.8, 13.0]	−0.31
Voyage: rerank-2.5-lite	35.2	35.7	[31.8, 39.6]	−0.71*
NVIDIA: Nemotron VL 1B	32.2	16.6	[12.3, 20.9]	−0.69*
Voyage: rerank-1	31.7	−12.6	[−17.7, −7.3]	0.60*
Qwen: Qwen3 8B	31.6	29.4	[25.6, 33.3]	−0.67*
Cohere: v4 fast	31.4	4.3	[0.0, 8.2]	0.14
Qwen: Qwen3 0.6B	27.5	6.9	[1.8, 11.7]	0.00
Qwen: Qwen3 4B	21.6	7.9	[3.7, 12.2]	−0.28
Mixedbread: large v2	20.8	−14.8	[−18.2, −11.4]	0.60*
Voyage: rerank-2-lite	19.2	−18.1	[−23.0, −13.0]	0.46*
IBM: Granite r2	15.3	5.3	[0.5, 10.0]	−0.34
BAAI: BGE v2-m3	15.1	5.5	[1.4, 9.5]	−0.21
Jina: reranker v2[b]	14.3	12.2	[7.8, 16.8]	−0.47*
Jina: reranker v3[c]	2.3	2.0	[−2.8, 6.8]	0.09
Alibaba: GTE ModernBERT	−6.7	4.2	[−0.4, 8.8]	−0.38

We ran 6 rerankers again to separate length from content: Voyage rerank-3, Cohere rerank v5 pro, and Qwen3-Reranker-8B, which keep the pattern on whole résumés; Voyage rerank-2 and mxbai-rerank-large-v2, which reverse it; and bge-reranker-v2-m3, the worked reranker, whose contrast is small in both settings. Each scored the same 3,840 comparisons with the text after the prepended name cut to its first 35, 75, 150, 300, or 600 words or left whole, each with the name alone or with the name followed by the sentence "He is a dedicated professional, and his colleagues describe him as reliable and thorough" (or its female form), whose 14 words count toward the cut. The 35-word condition with the sentence resembles a synthetic document in length and in carrying a name and pronouns. Figure 4 shows every condition.

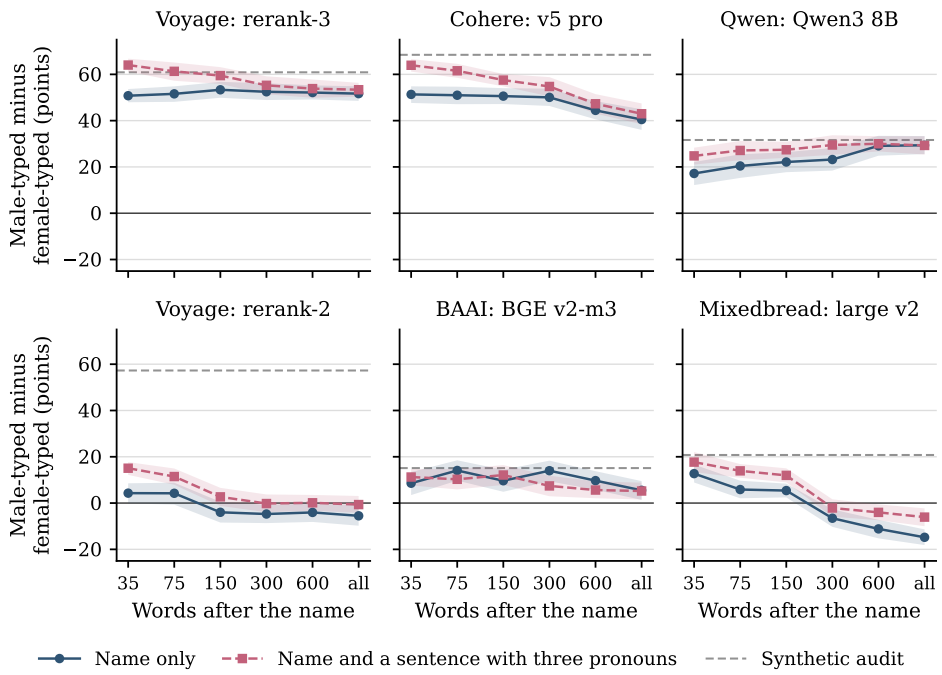


Figure 4: **Companion experiment by résumé length.** Each panel shows one reranker's male-typed minus female-typed contrast (points) as more of each résumé is kept, with the prepended name alone (solid) or with the name and a sentence carrying 3 of the applicant's pronouns (dashed), whose words count toward the length; "all" is the whole résumé. Only the applicant's own name and pronouns change. Bands are 95% intervals resampling pools within each job category; the dashed gray line is the reranker's contrast in the synthetic audit.

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